Democrats’ battleground leads are shakier than their national edge

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Variance across forecasters comes down to the weight placed on polls.
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Unified Democratic Congress would slow, not cut, defense spending
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Work authorization fee would roil higher education and corporates

This week in polling: Democrats’ battleground leads are shakier than their national edge. The negative national environment for Republicans showed no signs of abating this week: Democrats’ lead in the generic congressional ballot, per the Silver Bulletin average, increased to 9.2 points among all voters, while President Trump’s approval rating fell to a second-term low of 37.1%.

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Both of these factors contribute to our view that Democrats are now the stronger favorites to win both chambers of Congress, at 90% odds in the House and 60% in the Senate (please see Polling gains boost Democratic odds in House and Senate , 6 October 2026). We’re closer to a D+10 national environment than we are to the D+6 one which characterized most of the spring and summer.
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Despite that national swell, Democrats looked a tad weaker in the battleground states than last week. This doesn’t challenge our view that Democrats are the moderate favorites in the Senate; instead, it’s a reminder that the Senate is by no means a done deal.

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In Texas, Ken Paxton showed signs of life for the first time practically since his nomination, with a University of Massachusetts poll showing him tied against Democrat James Talarico. Paxton still trails by a few points in the average, but this poll—from a high-quality pollster—might suggest that Republicans’ advertising blitz is working.
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In Iowa, Democrat Josh Turek led by four in a Wednesday poll, but trailed by two points in two others. Those make this race a tie in our average of recent non-partisan polls—a contrast to Turek's two-point lead last week.

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In Michigan, meanwhile, two polls this week found Democrat Abdul El-Sayed just barely ahead of Republican Mike Rogers. Holding the Michigan seat is virtually a necessity for Democrats, and close polls there have an outsize overall effect.

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The positive signs for Democrats this week were in Maine, where Troy Jackson led Senator Susan Collins (R-ME) by four points in two polls, and in Kansas, where Senator Roger Marshall (R-KS) isn't ahead by much if he's ahead at all.

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Put together, these polls point to how Republicans could retain the Senate: If Democrats make enormous progress, relative to the 2024 baseline, in Republican-leaning states like Texas and Iowa, but come just barely short, within a couple of points, of victory in each.

Variance across forecasters comes down to the weight placed on polls. Quantitative election forecasters all see Democrats as the favorites to win the Senate, but they disagree on by how much Democrats are the favorites. There is nearly a 20-point gap in Democrats' odds to win the Senate across various forecasters. Nate Silver is the most bullish, at 75%; Decision Desk HQ is at 57%. Split Ticket and VoteHubUS are at 65% and 62% respectively. (Eurasia Group is on the lower end of that spectrum, at 60%.)

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This is more divergence across forecasters than we saw in 2024, when, a month out from the election, forecasters had only about a ten-point delta on Democrats' odds of winning the Senate.

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For the most part, this divergence comes down to how much weight the forecaster's model places on head-to-head polling, especially in the deep-red states like Kansas or Nebraska where Democrats are polling nearly neck-and-neck with Republicans this year. Nate Silver's model, for instance, gives Democrats nearly even odds to win Kansas, which is in line with recent polling; DDHQ's is far more skeptical, giving Democrats only 35% odds—in line with Kansas's strongly Republican fundamentals.

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In effect, whether you trust the more bullish forecasts comes down in large part to whether you trust that the polls—especially in the Plains states, but also in Texas and Alaska—aren't severely overstating the Democratic vote share, likely by simply missing a significant number of Republican voters. If Republicans hold on, this will be a comparatively better cycle for more fundamentals-based forecasters, while if Democrats win big—a 53-seat majority or more—the bold predictions from Silver will look prescient.

Unified Democratic Congress would slow, not cut, defense spending. Democrats are positioned to win unified control of both the House and Senate in the midterms (60% odds). Under unified control, Democrats would slow the rapid growth of defense topline spending seen in recent years but would still likely increase topline spending by 3.5-5%, in nominal terms.

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Weaknesses in the US defense industrial base and depleted interceptor stockpiles will still need to be addressed in the next legislative cycle. These strategic issues will create bipartisan political space to push for higher, if targeted, spending in the fiscal year 2028 funding process.

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Democrats would likely target large defense projects with weak political support on Capitol Hill, such as the Golden Fleet program, for reductions. Other key initiatives, such as the Sentinel intercontinental ballistic missile program and Virginia-class submarine program, would likely maintain political support for funding authorization.

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Democrats would also emphasize Pentagon process improvements, such as contracting reform, as part of their defense policy agenda. Even with Democratic control of both chambers of Congress, though, Republicans and industry lobbies will retain influence as private capital expands its role in defense and given the need to reach 60 votes for any legislation in the Senate.

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For more, please see Unified Democratic Congress would slow, not cut, defense spending 8 October 2026.

Work authorization fee would roil higher education and corporates. The Department of Homeland Security proposed a new $70,000 fee for international graduates of US universities to access the Optional Practical Training (OPT) program. The proposed rule, which is now out for public comment, is part of what appears to be a new slew of measures cracking down on skilled immigration, driven by Vice President JD Vance.

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The OPT proposal is the most significant of these announcements: Over a quarter million graduates are on OPT, which allows post-graduation employment of 12 to 24 months, each year, and it is a major source of employment authorization for entry-level, college-educated workers at major corporations. A new $70,000 fee, for which universities would be responsible, would severely restrict the availability of the program to most graduates.

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If the proposal goes through unaltered, it would likely make it much more difficult for US universities to recruit international students, who rely on OPT for immediate post-graduation employment; that would lead to a decline in the number of foreign students at US universities, with significant possible repercussions for their financial health, and would likely force corporations to reconstruct the pipeline for recruiting junior employees who aren’t US citizens.

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Industry and higher-education response during the comment period will be a key watchpoint, and it’s possible the administration will loosen the proposal—such as with exemptions for STEM-related majors—during the revision period. If finalized, the fate of the rule in the courts isn’t clear; in addition to the usual procedural challenges, critics will argue that the fee exceeds DHS’s statutory authority and in effect amounts to a new tax which only Congress can impose.

Quote of the Day

"I can do whatever I want if I want." - President Trump speaking to reporters this week about the possibility of being impeached again if Democrats take the House; he additionally threatened he could still do "very bad things" to Joe Biden, Barack Obama, and Hillary Clinton based on how they treated

him. Given the near-impossibility of removing an impeached president from office in the current political climate, the prospect of impeachment isn’t likely to be a constraint on Trump’s actions after the midterms.

On the Radar

12-18 October: IMF and World Bank Annual Meetings

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

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